

Figure 2.21 *Damghan, Semnan Province, Iran, stucco dado with palmettes, Sasanian. From Kröger 1982: tafel 89.*

Motifs of arches in series on the plastered surfaces of Ghur's remains – for example, toward the top of the Muna Ala tower (Figure 2.23), also discussed above – illustrate the capacious heuristic of architectural culture and the nature of the relationship between the Sasanian expanse's "cosmopolitan" stucco decoration, and the manifestation of these practices in the empire's eastern reaches in modern Afghanistan. These arcade motifs were also part of the iconography of Sasanian stucco decoration, as seen at sites such as Taq-i Bustan (*c.* fourth century CE) (Figure 2.24), where the finely worked stucco covering a column capital exhibited arches in series with exquisite, seashell-like striations in their semi-circular hoods. This common decorative motif was, as is evident, adapted into the local repertory of south–central Ghur as well, but here the fine, shell-inspired lines were interpreted as a broad three-lobed design – likely the outcome of the differing pliancy of the available plaster and the skill of the artisans working it.